VOLUME 4

# Reader Questions

## Questions on Difficult Bible Verses



READERS QUESTION SERIES

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Volume 4: Questions on Difficult Bible Verses

**HOW TO READ THIS VOLUME**

Each entry takes one question a reader has asked about one verse or short passage. It states what the verse means, and then argues that meaning from the verse's own passage and the chapter or chapters before it. The Scripture elsewhere is used as support, not as the foundation. Each entry marks what the text states, what the context shows, and what is inferred, so that the reader can see what carries the weight and judge it. The entries argue a position. Where other readings are held by named writers, they are set beside it with the places where each strains.

Scripture is quoted from the King James Version (KJV). Modern writers are named by author and work; their views are described in the entry's own words, and no quotation marks are used for them.

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# 1. What Does “He That Endureth to the End Shall Be Saved” Mean in Matthew 10:22 and 24:13?

**THE ANSWER**

It is a promise to Israel’s remnant in the Tribulation: the one who holds out to the end of those days will be brought through alive. “The end” is the end of the Tribulation, when the Son of man comes, and not the end of a person’s life; “saved” is physical deliverance through the persecution and the deceptions of that time, and not eternal salvation. The Lord says it first to the Twelve, sent “to the lost sheep of the house of Israel,” and again on the mount of Olives in answer to a question about “the end of the world.” Endurance here is survival, not merit, and eternal salvation is never made to hang on endurance in any program. The saying was not spoken to the Body, which is not in the Tribulation and is not under kingdom requirements; its salvation rests on believing the gospel Paul preached (1 Corinthians 15:1–4).

## Where the Verses Stand

The saying appears twice. In Matthew 10 the Lord sends out the Twelve, forbids them the way of the Gentiles and of the Samaritans, and tells them what they will meet: hatred, courts, betrayal. The saying closes that warning, and the next verse says they will not have gone over the cities of Israel before the Son of man comes. In Matthew 24 the disciples ask for the sign of his coming and “of the end of the world,” and the Lord’s answer runs through wars, afflictions, betrayal and cooling love to the same words, followed by the preaching of “this gospel of the kingdom” and then the end.

| Verse | KJV text | What to observe |
|---|---|---|
| 10:5–6 | “These twelve Jesus sent forth, and commanded them, saying, Go not into the way of the Gentiles, and into any city of the Samaritans enter ye not: But go rather to the lost sheep of the house of Israel.” | The Twelve are sent to Israel only. |
| 10:22–23 | “And ye shall be hated of all men for my name’s sake: but he that endureth to the end shall be saved. But when they persecute you in this city, flee ye into another: for verily I say unto you, Ye shall not have gone over the cities of Israel, till the Son of man be come.” | The saying; the cities of Israel and the coming of the Son of man. |
| 24:3 | “And as he sat upon the mount of Olives, the disciples came unto him privately, saying, Tell us, when shall these things be? and what shall be the sign of thy coming, and of the end of the world?” | The question: the sign of his coming and “the end of the world.” |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 24:9–14 | “Then shall they deliver you up to be afflicted, and shall kill you: and ye shall be hated of all nations for my name’s sake. And then shall many be offended, and shall betray one another, and shall hate one another. And many false prophets shall rise, and shall deceive many. And because iniquity shall abound, the love of many shall wax cold. But he that shall endure unto the end, the same shall be saved. And this gospel of the kingdom shall be preached in all the world for a witness unto all nations; and then shall the end come.” | Affliction, hatred “of all nations”; “shall endure unto the end”; the gospel of the kingdom. |

## What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** in Matthew 10 the audience is the Twelve, sent to Israel and told to avoid the Gentiles (10:5–6), and the saying sits inside a mission that is to run on “till the Son of man be come” (10:23). The saying belongs to that setting.
- **Stated:** in Matthew 24 the disciples ask about the end of the age, and the preaching that precedes it is “this gospel of the kingdom” (24:14), the message the Twelve carried to Israel, not the gospel of the grace of God.
- **Shown by the context:** “saved” in the same chapter sits beside the rescue of living people: “except those days should be shortened, there should no flesh be saved: but for the elect’s sake those days shall be shortened” (24:22), and the elect are then gathered by the angels at the coming of the Son of man (24:30–31). To be saved here is to be kept alive through the affliction and delivered at the coming of the Son of man.
- **Shown by the context:** the people addressed are called “the elect” (24:22, 31), already chosen. The text does not describe endurance as a purchase of that standing; it describes what the chosen are brought through, and the end it names is the one the disciples asked about (24:3), the close of the age and the coming of the Son of man.
- **Inferred:** that “the end” is the close of the Tribulation, that “saved” is deliverance of the living and that endurance is survival and not merit. The verse says only that the one who endures “shall be saved”; the argument rests on the audience, on 24:22, where the rescue is of “flesh,” and on the rest of Scripture, where faith and never endurance is the means of eternal salvation.

## The Other Readings

**A promise to every believer through the age.** Many commentaries read the saying as the perseverance by which genuine disciples are known in any age, leading to final salvation. It must explain why the setting is so specific, with Israel’s cities, the Twelve’s mission and the abomination and the Son of man’s coming, and why Paul never tells the Body its salvation waits on endurance. **A deliverance for Israel’s remnant.** Others read the discourse as addressed to Israel and the saved as those brought through the tribulation to the kingdom, which is the reading taken here. **Rescue of the living through the Tribulation.** This reading takes “the end” as the end of the Tribulation and “saved” as deliverance of the body, which fits 24:22 and is taken here.

| Reading | What it must say | Where it strains |
|---|---|---|
| Every believer through the age | Endurance marks and ensures final salvation for any disciple. | Israel's cities and the tribulation setting; the Body's salvation by believing. |
| Israel's remnant brought through | The faithful are delivered at the coming. | It must show the setting limits the saying; the text does say so (10:23; 24:3). |
| Rescue of the living through the Tribulation | "The end" is the end of the Tribulation; "saved" is physical deliverance. | 24:22 speaks of "flesh" being saved; the Lord's own question at 24:3. |

## What It Means for the Reader

The verse is not asking the reader in the Body to endure in order to be saved. Paul says the Body was "sealed with that holy Spirit of promise, which is the earnest of our inheritance until the redemption" (Ephesians 1:13–14), and he does ask the Body to be "stedfast, unmoveable" in the Lord's work (1 Corinthians 15:58), but he never says its salvation hangs on it. The verse tells the reader what the Lord promised the faithful in Israel in the days of that affliction.

## Related Reading

**Digital Studies:** Study 29, One Taken and the Other Left, reports the sayings of Matthew 24 as written; this entry argues who the endurance verse is addressed to. **Commentary Series:** Gospel, Volume 3, The Olivet Discourse. **Doctrinal Packets:** Matthew. **Readers Question Series:** Volume 2, entry 1, on who is taken and who is left.

# 2. What Does “Faith without Works Is Dead” Mean in James 2:26?

**THE ANSWER**

It means that a faith which is only a claim, with nothing done, is lifeless and useless, as a body without breath is lifeless. James writes to “the twelve tribes which are scattered abroad,” Israel’s prophetic remnant, and his examples, Abraham and Rahab, are figures of Israel’s covenant story. In that setting faith is expected to express itself in covenant obedience, and works are what show the faith is alive: “I will shew thee my faith by my works.” Works do not save; they demonstrate living faith. This is not Paul’s teaching on justification, which is salvation by grace through faith alone for the Body. James addresses faithfulness within Israel’s prophetic identity, and the Body’s works relate to reward and not to justification (1 Corinthians 3:11–15).

## Where the Verse Stands

James’s letter opens by naming its readers, the twelve tribes scattered abroad (1:1), and the argument of chapter 2 begins with a case: a believer who says to a hungry brother, “Depart in peace, be ye warmed and filled,” and gives him nothing. James asks whether such faith, “can faith save him?”, answers that it is “dead, being alone,” and then shows the point by Abraham offering Isaac and Rahab sending out the messengers. The verse is the closing comparison: as the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without works is dead.

| Verse | KJV text | What to observe |
|---|---|---|
| 1:1 | “James, a servant of God and of the Lord Jesus Christ, to the twelve tribes which are scattered abroad, greeting.” | The letter is addressed to “the twelve tribes.” |
| 2:14–17 | “What doth it profit, my brethren, though a man say he hath faith, and have not works? can faith save him? If a brother or sister be naked, and destitute of daily food, And one of you say unto them, Depart in peace, be ye warmed and filled; notwithstanding ye give them not those things which are needful to the body; what doth it profit? Even so faith, if it hath not works, is dead, being alone.” | The case of the hungry brother; “can faith save him?”; “dead, being alone.” |
| 2:18–19 | “Yea, a man may say, Thou hast faith, and I have works: shew me thy faith without thy works, and I will shew thee my faith by my works. Thou believest that there is one God; thou doest well: the devils also believe, and tremble.” | “I will shew thee my faith by my works”; the devils also believe. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 2:21–26 | “Was not Abraham our father justified by works, when he had offered Isaac his son upon the altar? Seest thou how faith wrought with his works, and by works was faith made perfect? And the scripture was fulfilled which saith, Abraham believed God, and it was imputed unto him for righteousness: and he was called the Friend of God. Ye see then how that by works a man is justified, and not by faith only. Likewise also was not Rahab the harlot justified by works, when she had received the messengers, and had sent them out another way? For as the body without the spirit is dead, so faith without works is dead also.” | Abraham and Rahab “justified by works”; the body without the spirit. |

## What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the letter is written to “the twelve tribes which are scattered abroad” (1:1) His readers are Israel’s prophetic remnant, and his examples, Abraham and Rahab, are covenant figures.
- **Stated:** the faith James calls dead is the faith of a man who “say he hath faith, and have not works” (2:14), and he compares it with the belief of the devils, who “believe, and tremble” (2:19). It is assent without life.
- **Shown by the context:** the test James sets is visible to others: “I will shew thee my faith by my works” (2:18). “Justified” in the examples of Abraham and Rahab is what their acts showed and established before men, since James quotes Genesis 15:6, “Abraham believed God, and it was imputed unto him for righteousness” (2:23), as already true before the offering of Isaac.
- **Shown by the context:** Paul writes to the Body of a standing before God that is received by faith “without the deeds of the law” (Romans 3:28), and of “him that worketh not, but believeth” (Romans 4:5). The question James answers, what a profession is worth within Israel’s covenant life, is not the question Paul answers.
- **Inferred:** that James’s “justified” means vindicated or shown to be righteous, and not the declaring righteous that Paul treats. The word is used in both letters, and the argument rests on James’s own tests, 2:18 and 2:23, and on the different audiences.

## The Other Readings

**Works as necessary evidence of saving faith.** Douglas Moo (*The Letter of James*, Pillar New Testament Commentary) and Peter Davids (*The Epistle of James*, New International Greek Testament Commentary) read James as speaking of the judgment before God, where only a faith that has produced works will stand. It must explain James’s own limits, a faith alone shown before men, and why a letter to Israel’s believers is read as setting out the terms of the Body’s salvation. **Deliverance, not eternal salvation.** Zane Hodges (*The Epistle of James: Proven Character Through Testing*) takes “save” in 2:14 as deliverance from the temporal ruin of a barren life. Zane Hodges reads the word the same way in 5:20. Others object that “save” in the New Testament most often speaks of eternal salvation, and the entry answers from the setting of James 2 itself.

| Reading | What it must say | Where it strains |
|---|---|---|
| Evidence before God | Only faith with works stands in the final judgment. | The tests James names are shown before others; the letter's readers. |
| Works prove faith alive before men | Works show the faith is real; "justified" means vindicated. | It must answer Paul's use of the same word. |
| Deliverance from temporal ruin | "Save" is a rescue in this life. | "Save" is used of the soul in 5:20. |

## What It Means for the Reader

The verse warns against a faith that stops at saying. It does not state the terms on which the Body is saved, and it does not undo Paul's word that the Body is saved by grace through faith, "not of works" (Ephesians 2:8–9). The reader in the Body is told of works in another way, as the fruit of what God has already done, and as bearing on reward and not on justification: "we are his workmanship, created in Christ Jesus unto good works" (Ephesians 2:10).

## Related Reading

**Digital Studies:** Study 15, Faith and Works in James and Paul, reports the two letters as written and keeps them apart; this entry argues what James 2:26 means. **Commentary Series:** none listed. **Doctrinal Packets:** James.

# 3. What Does “Baptism Doth Also Now Save Us” Mean in 1 Peter 3:21?

**THE ANSWER**

Peter writes to Israel’s scattered believers, and water baptism belongs to Israel’s covenant response in the kingdom offer and the early part of Acts (“Repent, and be baptized,” Acts 2:38). He calls baptism the answering figure to the ark: as eight souls were brought through the flood by water, so baptism now “saves” in a figure, and he guards the point at once. “Saves” here is deliverance from the judgment that hung over Israel in that prophetic setting, not eternal salvation; and it is “not the putting away of the filth of the flesh,” but “the answer of a good conscience toward God,” which in Israel’s setting is a covenant loyalty, with the saving “by the resurrection of Jesus Christ.” It is not the Body’s baptism, the one baptism of Ephesians 4:5 and the Spirit’s baptism into the one body (1 Corinthians 12:13). Paul says Christ sent him “not to baptize, but to preach the gospel” (1 Corinthians 1:17), which shows water baptism is no part of the saving message of the Body.

## Where the Verse Stands

Peter writes to “the strangers scattered” (1:1) who are suffering for doing right, and in 3:18–22 he says that Christ suffered once, the just for the unjust, was put to death in the flesh and was quickened by the Spirit. He then goes back to the days of Noah, when “few, that is, eight souls were saved by water.” Verse 21 says baptism is the like figure, qualifies it in a parenthesis, and attaches the saving to the resurrection. The passage ends with Christ at God’s right hand and every power subject to him.

| Verse | KJV text | What to observe |
|---|---|---|
| 1:1 | “Peter, an apostle of Jesus Christ, to the strangers scattered throughout Pontus, Galatia, Cappadocia, Asia, and Bithynia,” | The readers are the scattered strangers. |
| 3:20 | “Which sometime were disobedient, when once the longsuffering of God waited in the days of Noah, while the ark was a preparing, wherein few, that is, eight souls were saved by water.” | “Eight souls were saved by water.” |
| 3:21–22 | “The like figure whereunto even baptism doth also now save us (not the putting away of the filth of the flesh, but the answer of a good conscience toward God,) by the resurrection of Jesus Christ: Who is gone into heaven, and is on the right hand of God; angels and authorities and powers being made subject unto him.” | The like figure; “not the putting away of the filth of the flesh”; “by the resurrection of Jesus Christ.” |

## What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Peter does not say that water saves. He says it is “not the putting away of the filth of the flesh,” and that the saving is “by the resurrection of Jesus Christ” (3:21).
- **Stated:** the thing baptism corresponds to is “the answer of a good conscience toward God.” The baptized person answers God in covenant loyalty, and the rite expresses that answer.

- **Shown by the context:** the figure is the ark. The eight were brought safely through the judgment by the ark and the water that bore it, and the likeness Peter draws is of deliverance through a judgment by what God provided. That is why he cannot mean that the water cleanses.
- **Shown by the context:** the readers are Israel's scattered believers (1:1), to whom the Lord's commission in Matthew 28:19 and Peter's own word at Pentecost, "Repent, and be baptized" (Acts 2:38), were addressed. Baptism in these passages sits within Israel's program.
- **Inferred:** that the "saving" is deliverance from judgment in Israel's prophetic setting, not eternal salvation, and that the good conscience is covenant loyalty. The argument rests on Peter's denial of the water's cleansing, on his attaching the saving to the resurrection and on the Body's being told that Christ sent Paul "not to baptize, but to preach the gospel" (1 Corinthians 1:17).

## The Other Readings

**Baptism as the means of grace.** Some argue that in the New Testament baptism is the act in which God's grace in Christ is received by faith, and take the verse as saying so. It must explain why Peter immediately denies any cleansing by the water, and why the Body's apostle puts preaching above baptizing. **An appeal for a clear conscience.** Many commentaries take the answer or appeal to be a pledge or request to God for a clear conscience, with the saving effected by the resurrection and baptism as its outward sign. That is close to the reading taken here, with the added point that the baptism is Israel's.

| Reading | What it must say | Where it strains |
|---|---|---|
| Baptism conveys grace | The rite is the occasion of God's saving act. | "Not the putting away of the filth"; 1 Corinthians 1:17. |
| An appeal for a clear conscience | Baptism is the believer's answer to God; Christ's resurrection saves. | It must show the figure's limit, which Peter himself states. |
| Israel's baptism, a figure of the ark | Deliverance from judgment in Israel's setting through covenant loyalty; not the Body's. | It must show the letter's readers are Israel's believers; 1:1. |

## What It Means for the Reader

The verse does not make water the ground of anyone's salvation, and Peter denies it in the verse itself. It speaks to Israel's remnant and must stay there. For the Body, salvation is by believing the gospel Paul preached, and the Body's baptism is the work of the Spirit (1 Corinthians 12:13), the subject of Volume 2, entry 4.

## Related Reading

**Digital Studies:** Study 42, One Baptism, reports the baptisms of Scripture as written; this entry argues what Peter says baptism does. **Doctrinal Packets:** 1 Peter. **Readers Question Series:** Volume 2, entry 4, on water baptism; Volume 3, entry 6, on the spirits in prison in the same passage.

# 4. What Does "Call upon the Name of the Lord" Mean in Romans 10:13?

**THE ANSWER**

It is Israel's own way of seeking the Lord's deliverance. Paul quotes the line from Joel 2:32, where "whosoever shall call on the name of the Lord shall be delivered" belongs to the day of the Lord, to "mount Zion and in Jerusalem" and to "the remnant whom the Lord shall call." Romans 9–11 is addressed to Israel and concerns Israel, and Paul's point at 10:12–13 is that the Lord is "the same Lord over all" and that no difference is made between the Jew and the Greek who call on him. The phrase is Israel's covenantal cry for deliverance; for the Body it is not a sinner's prayer and not the way of being saved. Calling expresses faith and is not the mechanism of salvation. The Body is saved by believing the gospel Paul preached (1 Corinthians 15:1–4), and what Paul says of the Body's salvation is in Ephesians 2:8–9.

## Where the Verse Stands

Romans 10 opens with Paul's prayer for Israel, "that they might be saved," and with the charge that they have "a zeal of God, but not according to knowledge," going about to establish their own righteousness. He then draws on Deuteronomy 30 for the word that is "nigh thee," gives the confession and belief of 10:9–10, and closes the thought with two Scripture quotations, Isaiah 28:16 and Joel 2:32. Joel's verse sits in a passage about the outpouring of the Spirit on Israel, signs in the heavens "before the great and the terrible day of the Lord," and deliverance in Zion.

| Verse | KJV text | What to observe |
|---|---|---|
| Joel 2:32 | "And it shall come to pass, that whosoever shall call on the name of the Lord shall be delivered: for in mount Zion and in Jerusalem shall be deliverance, as the Lord hath said, and in the remnant whom the Lord shall call." | The call and the deliverance in Zion and for "the remnant." |
| Acts 2:21 | "And it shall come to pass, that whosoever shall call on the name of the Lord shall be saved." | Peter quotes Joel to Israel at Pentecost. |
| Rom 10:12–13 | "For there is no difference between the Jew and the Greek: for the same Lord over all is rich unto all that call upon him. For whosoever shall call upon the name of the Lord shall be saved." | "No difference between the Jew and the Greek"; "whosoever shall call." |

## What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** Romans 10:13 quotes Joel 2:32 and Acts 2:21 quotes the same verse, both to Israel. The line has a home in Israel's prophets before Paul uses it.
- **Stated:** Joel gives the verse its terms: the call is made in a time of judgment, the deliverance is "in mount Zion and in Jerusalem," and it reaches "the remnant whom the Lord shall call." In Joel the call is the way of Israel's deliverance on the day of the Lord.
- **Shown by the context:** Paul's chapters concern Israel, whom he longs to see saved (10:1), and his point at 10:12 is that the Lord's riches reach the Greek who calls as

well as the Jew who calls. The “no difference” is about who may call within that promise; it is not an announcement of a way for the Body to be saved.

- **Shown by the context:** where Paul says how the Body is saved he does not use this line. He writes of the gospel “which I preached unto you” (1 Corinthians 15:1–4) and of “by grace are ye saved through faith” (Ephesians 2:8). When he describes the Corinthian saints as “all that in every place call upon the name of Jesus Christ our Lord” (1 Corinthians 1:2) he is naming who they are, not giving a condition.
- **Inferred:** that the phrase carries Joel’s sense in Romans 10, the cry of the one who looks to the Lord for the deliverance he has promised. The argument rests on the quotation, on Joel’s setting and on the chapters’ concern with Israel.

## The Other Readings

**A universal gospel promise.** Many commentaries read Romans 10:13 as the promise of salvation to everyone who looks to Jesus as Lord, Paul applying Joel’s “Lord” to Christ. It must explain why the chapter’s subject is Israel, why Paul’s own statements of how the Body is saved do not use the line, and why Joel’s verse has its own remnant and Zion. **Deliverance of Israel’s remnant.** Others read Joel’s verse of the survival and deliverance of the faithful in the day of the Lord, which is the sense taken here.

| Reading | What it must say | Where it strains |
|---|---|---|
| A promise to all who believe | Anyone anywhere who calls on Jesus is saved. | The chapters’ subject is Israel; Paul’s Body statements; Joel’s Zion and remnant. |
| Israel’s deliverance, open to the Greek who calls | Joel’s promise in Israel’s line, with no difference between Jew and Greek who call. | It must show Paul does not make this the Body’s way; 1 Corinthians 15:1–4. |

## What It Means for the Reader

The phrase tells what Israel’s remnant does in the day Joel describes, and Paul’s use of it shows that the Greek who calls is not shut out of that promise. It does not give the Body a formula. Where the Body is told how it is saved, the words are belief in the gospel of Christ’s death for our sins, his burial and his rising (1 Corinthians 15:3–4), (Ephesians 2:8).

## Related Reading

**Digital Studies:** Study 21, Israel’s Judicial Blinding, reports Paul’s argument in Romans 9–11 as written; this entry argues one phrase of chapter 10. **Doctrinal Packets:** Romans. **Readers Question Series:** Volume 1, entry 6, on Romans 10:9–10, and Volume 2, entry 7, on “all Israel.”

# 5. What Does “Judge Not” Mean in Matthew 7:1?

**THE ANSWER**

The Lord forbids the censorious, self-exempting judging of a brother, the kind that sees “the mote” in another’s eye and will not look at “the beam” in one’s own, and he warns that the measure used will come back on the one who uses it. He does not forbid discernment. In the same passage he commands his hearers to “Give not that which is holy unto the dogs” and to know false prophets “by their fruits,” which cannot be done without judging. The saying is part of the Sermon on the Mount, given to his disciples in Israel’s kingdom ministry. The Body has its own words on judging, and they show the saying is not universal: Paul tells it to judge matters within the assembly (1 Corinthians 5:12; 6:1–5) and not to judge a brother over disputable things (Romans 14). They are not this saying carried over.

## Where the Verse Stands

The Sermon begins with the Lord’s disciples coming to him on the mountain (5:1–2) and moves through the righteousness of the kingdom, giving, prayer, forgiveness and trust. Chapter 7 opens with this command and develops it at once: the measure that you use will be used on you (7:2), the man with a beam in his eye cannot rightly pull a mote from his brother’s (7:3–4), and he must first deal with himself “and then shalt thou see clearly” to help his brother (7:5). Verses 6 and 15–20 then ask for judgment about dogs, swine and false prophets.

| Verse | KJV text | What to observe |
|---|---|---|
| 7:1–2 | “Judge not, that ye be not judged. For with what judgment ye judge, ye shall be judged: and with what measure ye mete, it shall be measured to you again.” | “Judge not”; the measure returns. |
| 7:3–5 | “And why beholdest thou the mote that is in thy brother’s eye, but considerest not the beam that is in thine own eye? Or how wilt thou say to thy brother, Let me pull out the mote out of thine eye; and, behold, a beam is in thine own eye? Thou hypocrite, first cast out the beam out of thine own eye; and then shalt thou see clearly to cast out the mote out of thy brother’s eye.” | The mote and the beam; “first cast out the beam.” |
| 7:6 | “Give not that which is holy unto the dogs, neither cast ye your pearls before swine, lest they trample them under their feet, and turn again and rend you.” | “Give not that which is holy unto the dogs.” |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 7:15–20 | "Beware of false prophets, which come to you in sheep's clothing, but inwardly they are ravening wolves. Ye shall know them by their fruits. Do men gather grapes of thorns, or figs of thistles? Even so every good tree bringeth forth good fruit; but a corrupt tree bringeth forth evil fruit. A good tree cannot bring forth evil fruit, neither can a corrupt tree bring forth good fruit. Every tree that bringeth not forth good fruit is hewn down, and cast into the fire. Wherefore by their fruits ye shall know them." | "Ye shall know them by their fruits." |

## What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the command is followed at once by its explanation, and the explanation is about hypocrisy: "Thou hypocrite, first cast out the beam out of thine own eye; and then shalt thou see clearly to cast out the mote out of thy brother's eye" (7:5). The Lord names the fault that is forbidden.
- **Stated:** the Lord himself commands judgment of persons in the same chapter: whoever gives holy things to dogs is warned (7:6), and false prophets are to be recognized by their fruits (7:15–20). The command is not a ban on discernment.
- **Shown by the context:** the saying speaks to "his disciples" (5:1) in the setting of the kingdom ministry to Israel, and the Sermon's other sayings about forgiveness and measure (6:14–15) work in the same way, with the Father's dealings answering the disciple's own.
- **Shown by the context:** Paul's letters to the Body say related things in their own words: "do not ye judge them that are within?" (1 Corinthians 5:12), and "Let us not therefore judge one another any more" about a brother's conscience (Romans 14:13). Those letters do not quote or apply the Sermon.
- **Inferred:** that the one whose measure comes back is the Father who judges, since the passage does not say who measures; the argument rests on the Sermon's teaching about the Father's dealing in 6:14–15 and on the passive form of the verb.

## The Other Readings

**A ban on every judgment of the brother.** Some read the command as a prohibition of every judging of another, since the disciple stands under the Lord's own judgment. It must explain the Lord's commands in 7:6 and 7:15–20, and Paul's requirement to judge those within (1 Corinthians 5:12). **A ban on harsh, hypocritical judging.** Many take the command to forbid censorious, condemning judgment and not discernment, which is the sense taken here. It must explain why a Sermon on Israel's kingdom is read as a rule for every believer in every age, which the reading taken here denies, taking the Sermon as the kingdom's ethic offered to Israel.

| Reading | What it must say | Where it strains |
|---|---|---|
| All judging forbidden | No disciple may pass any verdict on a brother. | 7:6; 7:15–20; 1 Corinthians 5:12. |
| Censorious judging forbidden | Hypocritical, condemning judgment is banned; discernment commanded. | It must show why the Sermon's audience is Israel's disciples. |

## What It Means for the Reader

The verse teaches that the one who sits in judgment over a brother while ignoring his own fault will be measured by the same standard. It does not tell anyone to stop distinguishing truth from error. Where the Body is told how to deal with a brother, the words are in Romans 14 and 1 Corinthians 5, and they ask for the same humility in other terms, as in “judge nothing before the time” (1 Corinthians 4:5).

## Related Reading

**Digital Studies:** Study 62, Matthew 5:17–20, reports the opening of the Sermon as written; this entry argues one saying from its seventh chapter. **Commentary Series:** Gospel, Volume 1, The Sermon on the Mount. **Doctrinal Packets:** Matthew.

# 6. What Does “Until Seventy Times Seven” Mean in Matthew 18:22?

**THE ANSWER**

It means that there is no number at which forgiveness stops; the number is symbolic of limitless forgiveness, as God is patient with Israel. Peter asks how often he must forgive a brother who sins against him, and offers “till seven times?”, a generous count; the Lord answers, “Until seventy times seven,” and tells the parable of the servant who was forgiven ten thousand talents and would not forgive a hundred pence. The saying is given to Israel’s disciples in the kingdom ministry, where the Father’s forgiveness is shown answering the disciple’s own and ends with a warning, “if ye from your hearts forgive not.” Forgiveness is also taught in Paul’s letters, but this is not a Body command. The Body is told to forgive “even as God for Christ’s sake hath forgiven you,” which begins from forgiveness already given and carries no such warning.

## Where the Verses Stand

Matthew 18 gathers instruction for the Lord’s disciples: the little ones, the lost sheep, and what to do when a brother trespasses: tell him alone, then with witnesses, then “tell it unto the church.” Peter’s question follows directly, and the Lord’s answer opens the parable of the king who reckoned with his servants. The first servant was forgiven a debt he could never repay, and then seized a fellow servant who owed him a hundred pence. The king’s last word is that the heavenly Father will deal with the unforgiving the same way.

| Verse | KJV text | What to observe |
|---|---|---|
| 18:15–17 | “Moreover if thy brother shall trespass against thee, go and tell him his fault between thee and him alone: if he shall hear thee, thou hast gained thy brother. But if he will not hear thee, then take with thee one or two more, that in the mouth of two or three witnesses every word may be established. And if he shall neglect to hear them, tell it unto the church: but if he neglect to hear the church, let him be unto thee as an heathen man and a publican.” | The brother’s trespass; alone, with witnesses, then the church. |
| 18:21–22 | “Then came Peter to him, and said, Lord, how oft shall my brother sin against me, and I forgive him? till seven times? Jesus saith unto him, I say not unto thee, Until seven times: but, Until seventy times seven.” | Peter’s question; “Until seventy times seven.” |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 18:23–35 | “Therefore is the kingdom of heaven likened unto a certain king, which would take account of his servants. And when he had begun to reckon, one was brought unto him, which owed him ten thousand talents. But forasmuch as he had not to pay, his lord commanded him to be sold, and his wife, and children, and all that he had, and payment to be made. The servant therefore fell down, and worshipped him, saying, Lord, have patience with me, and I will pay thee all. Then the lord of that servant was moved with compassion, and loosed him, and forgave him the debt. But the same servant went out, and found one of his fellowservants, which owed him an hundred pence: and he laid hands on him, and took him by the throat, saying, Pay me that thou owest. And his fellowservant fell down at his feet, and besought him, saying, Have patience with me, and I will pay thee all. And he would not: but went and cast him into prison, till he should pay the debt. So when his fellowservants saw what was done, they were very sorry, and came and told unto their lord all that was done. Then his lord, after that he had called him, said unto him, O thou wicked servant, I forgave thee all that debt, because thou desiredst me: Shouldest not thou also have had compassion on thy fellowservant, even as I had pity on thee? And his lord was wroth, and delivered him to the tormentors, till he should pay all that was due unto him. So likewise shall my heavenly Father do also unto you, if ye from your hearts forgive not every one his brother their trespasses.” | The unforgiving servant; “if ye from your hearts forgive not.” |

## What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the answer is a number that no one counts to: “Until seventy times seven.” Peter’s “seven times” was already the limit the teachers allowed, and the Lord replaces any limit with an immeasurable one.
- **Stated:** the parable contrasts “ten thousand talents” with “an hundred pence,” a debt too large to pay and a debt small by comparison. The point is the disproportion between what was forgiven and what was refused.
- **Shown by the context:** the saying is part of the Lord’s instruction to his disciples about life among them, and the parable begins “the kingdom of heaven is likened.” The standard is the Father’s dealing with his kingdom’s servants, and its sanction is that the Father “do also unto you, if ye from your hearts forgive not.”
- **Shown by the context:** the Body’s word is of a different shape: “forgiving one another, even as God for Christ’s sake hath forgiven you” (Ephesians 4:32). It grounds the forgiving in a forgiveness already received and attaches no sanction.
- **Inferred:** that the saying does not set aside the pattern of 18:15–17 or Luke 17:3–4 (“if he repent, forgive him”), since the Lord there says what to do with a brother

who sins, and here says how often to forgive one who does. Whether forgiveness is offered before repentance is not settled by this passage.

## The Other Readings

**Seventy-seven times.** Commentators note that the Greek can be read as seventy-seven times, which recalls Lamech's boast of vengeance "seventy and sevenfold" (Genesis 4:24), so that the Lord reverses Lamech's vengeance into forgiveness. The sense is the same: no ceiling. **Forgiveness only for the repentant.** Some read Luke 17:3–4 as limiting forgiveness to the one who repents, and set the saying inside it. It must explain why Peter asks how often, and why the Lord answers with a figure that no one counts.

| Reading | What it must say | Where it strains |
|---|---|---|
| 490 times, or 77 | A number so large (or so doubled) that it is not a limit. | The Greek can be read either way; the sense is the same. |
| Only when he repents | Forgiveness is owed each time he returns and repents. | Peter's question has no "if he repent"; the parable's debtor asked for patience. |

## What It Means for the Reader

The reader is shown the size of what has been forgiven him and the smallness of what is owed him. In the Body, the same pattern is given in its own terms: the forgiving is the answer to a forgiveness already received, not the condition of it.

## Related Reading

**Parable Studies:** The Unforgiving Servant. **Commentary Series:** Gospel, Volume 2, The Lord's Ministry to Israel. **Doctrinal Packets:** Matthew.

# 7. What Does “Sell All That Thou Hast” Mean in Luke 18:22?

**THE ANSWER**

It is the Lord’s own test of one man, a command to an individual and not a universal rule, a ruler who asked what he must do to inherit eternal life, and it is part of the kingdom discipleship he set before Israel. The ruler said he had kept the commandments from his youth. The Lord answered, “Yet lackest thou one thing: sell all that thou hast, and distribute unto the poor,” and the man went away “very sorrowful: for he was very rich.” The command exposed what ruled him. It is not a rule that the Body must sell its possessions; the Twelve’s company in Acts 2–4 shared what it had in expectation of the kingdom, and Paul never commands the Body to sell all. Paul tells the Body’s rich to be “ready to distribute,” which is a different instruction, and nothing in the saying makes poverty the price of salvation.

## Where the Verse Stands

A ruler comes to the Lord with a question, “what shall I do to inherit eternal life?” The Lord asks why he calls him good, lists the commandments, and hears that he has kept them all. Then comes the one thing he lacks. When the ruler goes away, the Lord says how hard it is for the rich to enter the kingdom, the bystanders ask “Who then can be saved?”, and the Lord answers that what is impossible with men is possible with God. Peter then says that the disciples have left all, and the Lord promises what those who leave all for the kingdom’s sake will receive.

| Verse | KJV text | What to observe |
|---|---|---|
| 18:18–21 | “And a certain ruler asked him, saying, Good Master, what shall I do to inherit eternal life? And Jesus said unto him, Why callest thou me good? none is good, save one, that is, God. Thou knowest the commandments, Do not commit adultery, Do not kill, Do not steal, Do not bear false witness, Honour thy father and thy mother. And he said, All these have I kept from my youth up.” | The question; the commandments; “All these have I kept.” |
| 18:22–23 | “Now when Jesus heard these things, he said unto him, Yet lackest thou one thing: sell all that thou hast, and distribute unto the poor, and thou shalt have treasure in heaven: and come, follow me. And when he heard this, he was very sorrowful: for he was very rich.” | “Sell all that thou hast”; “very sorrowful.” |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 18:24–27 | “And when Jesus saw that he was very sorrowful, he said, How hardly shall they that have riches enter into the kingdom of God! For it is easier for a camel to go through a needle’s eye, than for a rich man to enter into the kingdom of God. And they that heard it said, Who then can be saved? And he said, The things which are impossible with men are possible with God.” | The needle’s eye; “Who then can be saved?” |

## What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the man asks “what shall I do to inherit eternal life?” and is first answered with the commandments (Matthew 19:17: “if thou wilt enter into life, keep the commandments”). He is a ruler in Israel under the law, asking how to inherit.
- **Stated:** the command is addressed to him in the singular and is tied to a particular lack: “Yet lackest thou one thing.” It ends with “come, follow me,” the call of the Lord’s disciples in his earthly ministry.
- **Shown by the context:** the response shows what held him: “he was very rich.” The Lord then speaks of the rich entering the kingdom, and the disciples’ reaction, “Who then can be saved?”, shows that wealth was taken as a sign of favour. The answer is that salvation is possible with God and not by what men can do.
- **Shown by the context:** the call to leave all belongs to Israel’s kingdom discipleship in the Lord’s ministry, as in Luke 14:33, “whosoever he be of you that forsaketh not all that he hath, he cannot be my disciple,” and as in Volume 3, entry 1. The Jerusalem believers’ sharing of their goods (Acts 4:34) is reported in Acts 1–8, within Israel’s program.
- **Inferred:** that the saying is a particular test within that discipleship, and not a rule laid on every believer. The argument rests on the singular address, on Paul’s words to the Body’s rich (1 Timothy 6:17–19; Ephesians 4:28), which command giving and do not command selling all, and on the Body’s being saved by grace and not by what it gives up.

## The Other Readings

**A rule for every disciple.** Some take the ruler’s story as a picture of the call to leave everything that stands between the disciple and Christ, one that comes to everyone who would follow. It must explain why Paul does not command the Body to sell all, and why the Lord answered a man who asked how to inherit eternal life by doing. **A test of this man’s heart.** Many commentaries read the command as exposing the ruler’s attachment to wealth, which is close to the sense taken here. It must say whether the command also applies beyond him, and the entry says it belongs to Israel’s kingdom discipleship.

| Reading | What it must say | Where it strains |
|---|---|---|
| A call to every believer | All who follow must give up all. | 1 Timothy 6:17–19; Ephesians 4:28; the Body’s salvation by grace. |
| A test of this man’s heart | He is shown what ruled him. | Luke 14:33 shows a wider call; it belongs to Israel’s kingdom discipleship. |

## What It Means for the Reader

The reader is asked what holds him, as the ruler was. For the Body, the instruction is to be “rich in good works, ready to distribute, willing to communicate” (1 Timothy 6:18), and to work, “that he may have to give to him that needeth” (Ephesians 4:28). Neither makes salvation the reward of giving.

## Related Reading

**Commentary Series:** Gospel, Volume 2, The Lord’s Ministry to Israel. **Doctrinal Packets:** Luke. **Readers Question Series:** Volume 3, entry 1, on taking up the cross.

# 8. What Does “The Last Shall Be First” Mean in Matthew 19:30 and 20:16?

**THE ANSWER**

It is a saying about reward in the kingdom, and it warns those who count their service that God’s gift is his own to give. Peter has just asked, “what shall we have therefore?”, and the Lord promises the Twelve thrones “judging the twelve tribes of Israel” and a hundredfold to all who have left their all. Then he says “many that are first shall be last; and the last shall be first,” and tells the parable of the householder who paid every labourer a penny, and closes with the saying again. The first must not presume on their place, and the last may be given what the first received. The householder’s answer, “Is it not lawful for me to do what I will with mine own?”, is the point. It concerns reward in Israel’s kingdom and not the Body’s.

## Where the Verses Stand

Chapter 19 closes with Peter’s question and the Lord’s answer about the regeneration, the twelve thrones and everlasting life, and its last sentence is the saying. Chapter 20 opens with “For,” the parable that explains it: a householder hires labourers at dawn, at the third, sixth, ninth and eleventh hours, and pays them all a penny, beginning with the last. The first murmur, and he answers that he has done them no wrong. The parable ends with the saying again, with “for many be called, but few chosen.”

| Verse | KJV text | What to observe |
|---|---|---|
| 19:27–30 | “Then answered Peter and said unto him, Behold, we have forsaken all, and followed thee; what shall we have therefore? And Jesus said unto them, Verily I say unto you, That ye which have followed me, in the regeneration when the Son of man shall sit in the throne of his glory, ye also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel. And every one that hath forsaken houses, or brethren, or sisters, or father, or mother, or wife, or children, or lands, for my name’s sake, shall receive an hundredfold, and shall inherit everlasting life. But many that are first shall be last; and the last shall be first.” | Peter’s question; the twelve thrones; the saying. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 20:1–15 | "For the kingdom of heaven is like unto a man that is an householder, which went out early in the morning to hire labourers into his vineyard. And when he had agreed with the labourers for a penny a day, he sent them into his vineyard. And he went out about the third hour, and saw others standing idle in the marketplace, And said unto them; Go ye also into the vineyard, and whatsoever is right I will give you. And they went their way. Again he went out about the sixth and ninth hour, and did likewise. And about the eleventh hour he went out, and found others standing idle, and saith unto them, Why stand ye here all the day idle? They say unto him, Because no man hath hired us. He saith unto them, Go ye also into the vineyard; and whatsoever is right, that shall ye receive. So when even was come, the lord of the vineyard saith unto his steward, Call the labourers, and give them their hire, beginning from the last unto the first. And when they came that were hired about the eleventh hour, they received every man a penny. But when the first came, they supposed that they should have received more; and they likewise received every man a penny. And when they had received it, they murmured against the goodman of the house, Saying, These last have wrought but one hour, and thou hast made them equal unto us, which have borne the burden and heat of the day. But he answered one of them, and said, Friend, I do thee no wrong: didst not thou agree with me for a penny? Take that thine is, and go thy way: I will give unto this last, even as unto thee. Is it not lawful for me to do what I will with mine own? Is thine eye evil, because I am good?" | The labourers, the penny and the householder's answer. |
| 20:16 | "So the last shall be first, and the first last: for many be called, but few chosen." | "So the last shall be first, and the first last." |
| Luke 13:28–30 | "There shall be weeping and gnashing of teeth, when ye shall see Abraham, and Isaac, and Jacob, and all the prophets, in the kingdom of God, and you yourselves thrust out. And they shall come from the east, and from the west, and from the north, and from the south, and shall sit down in the kingdom of God. And, behold, there are last which shall be first, and there are first which shall be last." | The saying in another setting: Israel thrust out and others coming in. |

## What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the saying stands at both ends of the parable (19:30; 20:16), joined by "For" at 20:1. The parable is its explanation, and the saying must be read with it.
- **Stated:** the setting is the kingdom: the regeneration and the thrones (19:28), and the parable begins "the kingdom of heaven is like unto a man that is an householder." The reward is the kingdom's reward to the Twelve and to those who left all for the Lord's name.
- **Shown by the context:** the labourers complain about unequal service paid equally, and the householder answers by appeal to his agreement and his goodness: "Is thine eye evil, because I am good?" (20:15). The reward is gift according to the householder's word, not pay in proportion to the hours worked.
- **Shown by the context:** the saying has another setting in Luke 13:28–30, where those expecting to be in the kingdom are "thrust out" and others come "from the east, and from the west" to sit down in it: "there are last which shall be first, and there are first which shall be last." The reversal is the same, the people it concerns are fixed by each setting.
- **Inferred:** that "many be called, but few chosen" (20:16) speaks of the invitation to the kingdom and the proving of those in it, within Israel's program, and is not a statement on how God chooses the Body. The argument rests on the parable's setting and on Paul's separate account of the Body's election "before the foundation of the world" (Ephesians 1:4).

## The Other Readings

**Jesus' defence of the gospel to sinners.** Some read the parable as the Lord's answer to those who grudged his welcome of outcasts, the first being those who thought themselves righteous. It must explain why the parable is attached to Peter's question about reward. **Grace and reward in the kingdom.** Others read it as a lesson that the kingdom's rewards are given by God's generosity and not by the hours served, with a warning to the disciples who had left all, which is the reading taken here.

| Reading | What it must say | Where it strains |
|---|---|---|
| Defence of the gospel to sinners | The grudging first are the Pharisees; the last the outcasts. | It follows Peter's question about reward in 19:27. |
| The kingdom's reward is God's gift | The Twelve must not presume; the late may receive as the early. | It must state the reward is Israel's, and not the Body's. |

## What It Means for the Reader

The saying removes the habit of measuring one's service against another's and asking what is owed. The Body has its own account of reward, in the judgment seat of Christ where "every one may receive the things done in his body" (2 Corinthians 5:10), and it is not this parable.

## Related Reading

**Digital Studies:** Study 33, The Crowns of Scripture, reports the rewards of Scripture as written; this entry argues one saying. **Parable Studies:** The Laborers in the Vineyard; The Narrow Door. **Commentary Series:** Gospel, Volume 2, The Lord's Ministry to Israel.

# 9. What Does “My Yoke Is Easy” Mean in Matthew 11:30?

**THE ANSWER**

It is the Lord’s invitation to Israel’s weary to take his teaching in place of the burden that the scribes and Pharisees laid on them. “Come unto me, all ye that labour and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you, and learn of me.” A yoke is the discipleship of a pupil to his master, and the Lord’s yoke is “easy,” kind or good, because he is “meek and lowly in heart” and his burden is “light” beside the heavy burdens of the Pharisees (23:4). It is still a yoke and still asks him to be followed. It was spoken to Israel in the kingdom ministry and is not the Body’s call to be saved.

## Where the Verses Stand

Matthew 11 begins with John the Baptist’s question and the Lord’s answer, then his upbraiding of the cities where most of his works were done, Chorazin, Bethsaida and Capernaum, “because they repented not.” He thanks the Father that he has “hid these things from the wise and prudent, and hast revealed them unto babes,” says all things are delivered to him, and gives the invitation. Chapter 12 opens with the quarrel about the sabbath, where the Lord is “Lord even of the sabbath day,” and chapter 23 describes the scribes’ “heavy burdens and grievous to be borne.”

| Verse | KJV text | What to observe |
|---|---|---|
| 11:20–24 | “Then began he to upbraid the cities wherein most of his mighty works were done, because they repented not: Woe unto thee, Chorazin! woe unto thee, Bethsaida! for if the mighty works, which were done in you, had been done in Tyre and Sidon, they would have repented long ago in sackcloth and ashes. But I say unto you, It shall be more tolerable for Tyre and Sidon at the day of judgment, than for you. And thou, Capernaum, which art exalted unto heaven, shalt be brought down to hell: for if the mighty works, which have been done in thee, had been done in Sodom, it would have remained until this day. But I say unto you, That it shall be more tolerable for the land of Sodom in the day of judgment, than for thee.” | The cities that repented not. |
| 11:25–27 | “At that time Jesus answered and said, I thank thee, O Father, Lord of heaven and earth, because thou hast hid these things from the wise and prudent, and hast revealed them unto babes. Even so, Father: for so it seemed good in thy sight. All things are delivered unto me of my Father: and no man knoweth the Son, but the Father; neither knoweth any man the Father, save the Son, and he to whomsoever the Son will reveal him.” | The Father’s hiding and revealing; all things delivered to the Son. |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| 11:28–30 | “Come unto me, all ye that labour and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you, and learn of me; for I am meek and lowly in heart: and ye shall find rest unto your souls. For my yoke is easy, and my burden is light.” | “Come unto me”; “Take my yoke”; “easy” and “light.” |
| 23:1–4 | “Then spake Jesus to the multitude, and to his disciples, Saying, The scribes and the Pharisees sit in Moses’ seat: All therefore whatsoever they bid you observe, that observe and do; but do not ye after their works: for they say, and do not. For they bind heavy burdens and grievous to be borne, and lay them on men’s shoulders; but they themselves will not move them with one of their fingers.” | The scribes “bind heavy burdens and grievous to be borne.” |

## What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the invitation is to “all ye that labour and are heavy laden” and its promise is “rest unto your souls,” a phrase from Jeremiah 6:16, where Israel was told to ask for the old paths and “ye shall find rest for your souls” and answered, “We will not walk therein.”
- **Stated:** the Lord calls his yoke easy and his burden light, and in the same sentence says he is “meek and lowly in heart.” The ease is that of his character as teacher.
- **Shown by the context:** the people addressed are those in the cities of Galilee he has just upbraided and the multitudes he has taught, and the burden they carry is shown in chapter 23 to be the scribes’ rule “they bind heavy burdens and grievous to be borne.”
- **Shown by the context:** Paul’s word to the Body about a yoke is different. He tells it to “stand fast … in the liberty wherewith Christ hath made us free, and be not entangled again with the yoke of bondage” (Galatians 5:1), and Peter at Jerusalem calls the law “a yoke upon the neck of the disciples, which neither our fathers nor we were able to bear” (Acts 15:10).
- **Inferred:** that “my yoke” is the Lord’s own teaching and requirement in Israel’s kingdom ministry, light compared with the Pharisees’ load but still a yoke. The argument rests on the setting in Galilee, the Jeremiah allusion and the sermon’s demands, which the passage does not set aside.

## The Other Readings

**The Lord as wisdom, inviting all.** W. D. Davies and Dale Allison (*The Gospel According to Saint Matthew*, International Critical Commentary) and others hear the invitation against the call of wisdom in Sirach 51, with the Lord offering himself as the one who gives rest to all who come. It must explain why the call follows the woes on Israel’s cities and why the burden named is the scribes’, and why Paul never invites the Body by this call. **An offer to Israel.** Others take it as the Lord’s offer to Israel’s weary, the sense taken here.

| Reading | What it must say | Where it strains |
|---|---|---|
| A call to everyone, as wisdom calls | Anyone who is weary may come and find rest. | The woes on Israel's cities; the scribes' burden; Paul's gospel is stated otherwise. |
| An offer to Israel's weary | The Lord invites Israel's labouring to his teaching. | It must say what the yoke asks, which the sermon shows. |

## What It Means for the Reader

The verse shows who the Lord is to those who follow him: gentle, and not like the teachers who burdened them. It is not a way of being saved. The Body rests on what Paul says of grace and of liberty from the law, and does not take a yoke of the Mosaic kind (Galatians 5:1).

## Related Reading

**Digital Studies:** Study 59, The Law's Jurisdiction and the Body of Christ, reports the law's place as written; this entry argues one saying. **Commentary Series:** Gospel, Volume 2, The Lord's Ministry to Israel. **Doctrinal Packets:** Matthew.

# 10. What Does “We Shall Judge Angels” Mean in 1 Corinthians 6:3?

**THE ANSWER**

Paul is speaking to the Body of Christ, and “judge” here means to govern and administer, not to condemn. The Body inherits the heavenly places (Ephesians 2:6) and one day fills seats of authority in them that angelic rulers held, so that our “judging” angels is taking up their governing positions, an administrative judging, as the Twelve “judge” the twelve tribes by ruling them in the earthly kingdom. It is not punitive. Condemning judgment belongs to Christ, the Body never takes part in the great white throne, and the casting out of angels is Michael’s work in Revelation 12, not the Body’s. Paul’s argument is from the greater to the lesser: if the Body is to govern the heavenly realm, it is fit to settle disputes on earth. This is a destiny of the Mystery, not a promise of Israel’s prophetic program, and it never involves sentencing.

## Where the Verses Stand

Chapter 6 opens with a rebuke: brothers at Corinth are going to law with one another before the unbelieving courts. Paul’s answer is a series of questions beginning “Do ye not know”: that the saints shall judge the world, that they shall judge angels, and so that they ought to be able to judge matters “pertaining to this life.” He ends by asking why they do not rather suffer wrong.

| Verse | KJV text | What to observe |
|---|---|---|
| 6:1–2 | “Dare any of you, having a matter against another, go to law before the unjust, and not before the saints? Do ye not know that the saints shall judge the world? and if the world shall be judged by you, are ye unworthy to judge the smallest matters?” | Law before “the unjust”; “the saints shall judge the world.” |
| 6:3 | “Know ye not that we shall judge angels? how much more things that pertain to this life?” | “We shall judge angels”; “how much more things that pertain to this life?” |
| Eph 2:6 | “And hath raised us up together, and made us sit together in heavenly places in Christ Jesus:” | The Body made to sit “in heavenly places in Christ Jesus.” |
| Mt 19:28 | “And Jesus said unto them, Verily I say unto you, That ye which have followed me, in the regeneration when the Son of man shall sit in the throne of his glory, ye also shall sit upon twelve thrones, judging the twelve tribes of Israel.” | The Twelve “judging the twelve tribes of Israel.” |

## What Carries the Weight

- **Stated:** the verb is future and the subject is “we”: “we shall judge angels.” Paul states it as something the Corinthians already know, and builds his argument on it.
- **Stated:** the argument runs from greater to lesser: the world and angels, then “the smallest matters” and “things that pertain to this life” (6:2–3). The point is a fitness to rule and settle matters, which is how Paul uses it.

- **Shown by the context:** the Body is seated "in heavenly places in Christ Jesus" (Ephesians 2:6) and is seen "with him in glory" (Colossians 3:4). The judging belongs with that inheritance of the heavenly realm, and so to the Body's own destiny, not to Israel's earthly kingdom.
- **Shown by the context:** "judge" can mean to rule: the Twelve "judging the twelve tribes of Israel" (Matthew 19:28) are not said to condemn the tribes but to sit on thrones over them. The same verb gives a governing sense here.
- **Shown by the context:** Revelation 12:7–9 shows Michael and his angels fighting the dragon and his angels and casting them out; the Body is not the agent. The Body's own accounting is the judgment seat of Christ (2 Corinthians 5:10), a separate matter.
- **Inferred:** that "judge angels" means the Body takes up governing and administrative roles in the heavenly places formerly held by angelic rulers, with no sentencing. The verse does not say so in words; the argument rests on the sense of "judge" as rule, on Ephesians 2:6 and on the verse's use as an argument for fitness to govern.

## The Other Readings

**The saints' share in Christ's final judgment of the evil angels.** Commentators on 1 Corinthians take the judging as the saints' share in Christ's final judgment, with "angels" likely the evil ones, and the possibilities surveyed include that "judge" means "rule." The first sense must explain why Paul argues from fitness to govern, and why the Body would sentence when punitive judgment is Christ's. **Rule over the heavenly realm.** The sense of "judge" as governing is among those surveyed, and it is the one taken here. **Condemning by example.** Some take the saints' lives as condemning the world and angels by contrast; the verb is "shall judge," not shame.

| Reading | What it must say | Where it strains |
|---|---|---|
| Sentencing fallen angels with Christ | The Body shares in the verdict on rebellious angels. | Punitive judgment is Christ's; Revelation 12 shows Michael casting them out. |
| Governing the heavenly realm | "Judge" means rule; the Body takes the administrative roles angels held. | The verse does not name the offices; Ephesians 2:6 and Matthew 19:28 are its support. |
| Condemnation by example | The saints' lives condemn the world and the angels. | The verb is "shall judge," not shame. |

## What It Means for the Reader

Paul turns the reader's eye to what the Body is for. Those who will govern in the heavenly places are not too small to settle a dispute between brothers, and are to be wronged rather than disgrace the name of Christ before the world. The verse places the Body's future with Christ before its present quarrels.

## Related Reading

**Digital Studies:** Study 31, The Judgments of Scripture, reports the judgments as written; this entry argues one saying. **Commentary Series:** Prophecy & Mystery, Volume 5, Separate Courts. **Doctrinal Packets:** 1 Corinthians.

# Modern Writers Referred To

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Davies, W. D., and Dale C. Allison Jr. *A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on the Gospel According to Saint Matthew,* vol. 2. International Critical Commentary. Edinburgh: T&T Clark, 1991.
Hodges, Zane C. *The Epistle of James: Proven Character Through Testing.* Irving, TX: Grace Evangelical Society, 1994.
Moo, Douglas J. *The Letter of James.* Pillar New Testament Commentary. Grand Rapids: Eerdmans, 2000.

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